General Mutaguchi's invasion plan was originally rejected by his superiors. Mutaguchi's plan “Operation U (U-Go)” was eventually approved by the Southern Expeditionary Army in Singapore and the IGHQ in Tokyo. The key to the planned offensive was to gain control of the strategically important Imphal plain. If the Japanese could take control of the city of Imphal they could control access to plain in which an invading army would have to cross. Mutaguchi also planned a simultaneous attack on town of Kohima to cut off the British and Indian supply route to Imphal. If the Japanese could take Kohima ridge they could control the only road that led to the Allied supply depot at Dimapur leading to Imphal. Mutaguchi's plan was to use speed and surprise to encircle and destroy the numerically superior forward-deployed Indian troops at Torbung, Tamu, and Palel leading to Imphal. Once the Japanese captured Imphal they would secure much-needed provisions and munitions to sustain the momentum of their offensive.

The Indian IV Corp was responsible for the defense of Imphal. When the Japanese attacked, the British and Indian troops attempted to engage the Japanese on the plains near Imphal, forcing the Japanese to fight with an extended supply line. Unfortunately, the Allied commander reacted too late to lure the Japanese into a premature engagement. The Japanese offensive began on March 8, 1944, but the order to fall back to Imphal wasn't issued until five days later on March 13, 1944. As a result, Indian supply dumps and ordinance depots in the Chin Hills were captured by the Japanese and in the process they became encircled. The 214th Regiment of the 17th Division successfully counterattacked at Tuitum saddle on March 18, 1944, allowing the 17th Division to recover their supplies and safely retreat to Imphal on April 4, 1944. The Japanese pursued the withdrawing Indian troops. Once the Indian 17th Division reached Imphal, the Japanese attack began. The Japanese 33rd Division moved up the Kabow valley from their base in Tamu and attacked from Bishenpur. Units from both the 15th and 33rd Divisions then attacked Shenam saddle near Imphal, only to be stopped by the Indian troops. From the north, the Japanese attacked and captured the supply dump near the town of Kangpokpi and then captured Nungshigum Hill. The Japanese had anticipated that following the initial phase of their offensive, the Allies would retreat under pressure. Instead the Allies took positions along the roads on a 90-mile arc from Kanglatombi and Kameng, Shenam, and Bishenpur in the south. Unlike previous